something that possesses qualities or aptitudes that "approach" or "equal" those of another.[35] In other words, it should be a response that improves the military capabilities beyond that of deterrence, enables the state to be a counterweight, and preferably narrows (approaches) the power gap, although not necessarily equalling the capabilities of the rival state. If the power gap continues to widen vis-à-vis the state that is being balanced against, the state's internal efforts are not sufficient to resemble hard balancing, and external balancing may be required.

Moreover, entering into a military alliance excludes the option of hedging, because the state has then made a choice in terms of security alignment.[36] Although the signalling from external balancing in its nature is stronger than that of internal balancing regardless of its magnitude, to qualify as hard balancing, the internal measures alone should be of such proportions that they are not compatible with a strategy of hedging. While hedging aims to avoid heightening tension or causing conflict with a target state by maintaining a cooperative posture, a state pursuing an explicit hard balancing strategy is not concerned about provoking the target state.[37] Koga observes that "If the risk of balancing and bandwagoning exceed that of hedging, then security and autonomy are maximised by choosing hedging."[38] If we turn this argument around, it means that by choosing a strategy of hard balancing through internal measures the state calculates that this is a less risky strategy than hedging, and the efforts put into balancing should henceforth be sufficiently robust to contribute to maximisation of security and autonomy. The definition of hard balancing we present here is rather narrow: State A, engaged in an intense rivalry with State B, takes strong internal measures to rectify the imbalance in power through military build-up and changes in defence posture and/or adopts robust external efforts in the form of a formal military alliance with State C or forges some form of security